Discrimination in the EU

Survey Research Methodology II

2026-02-04

The European Commission conducted a Eurobarometer survey in 2019 focusing on discrimination within the European Union, with particular attention to the LGBTI community and ethnic minorities. This multi-country survey examined public attitudes as well as perceived legal and social challenges, revealing substantial cross-national variation across EU Member States. To further contextualise these findings, the tables presented below provide an overview of public attitudes toward different forms of discrimination-related behavior in Europe.

Table 1 below summarize the extent to which respondents agree or disagree with the statement that **gay, lesbian, and bisexual people should have the same rights as heterosexual people**. Since 2015, overall levels of acceptance have increased across most countries. However, in nine countries, respondents are now less likely to agree with this statement than they were in 2015. This decline is particularly pronounced in Bulgaria (-12 percentage points), as well as in Slovakia and Czechia (both -15 percentage points).

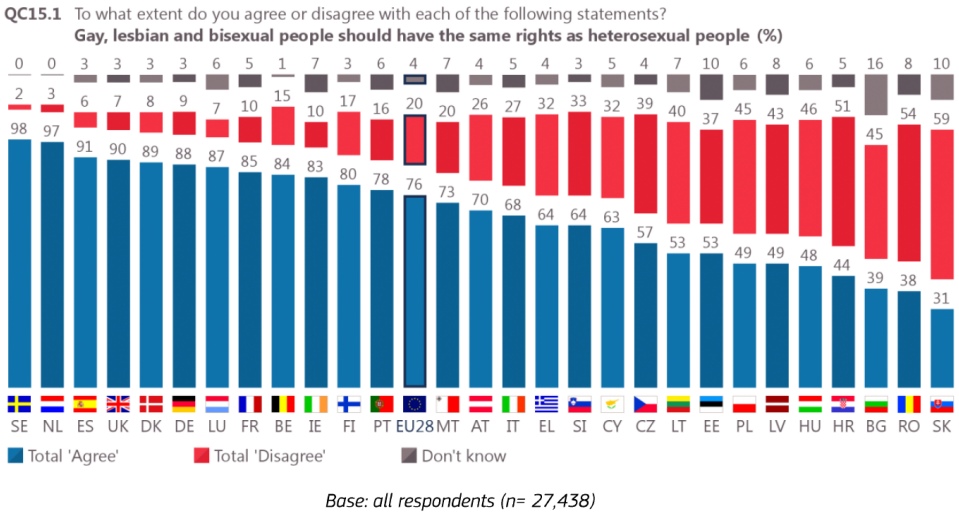

Figure 1: Table 1. Question QC15.1 by country

Table 2 refers to individuals' support for **including a third option in official documents, other than male or female**. As observed, almost half (46%) of all respondents believe that official documents should offer a third option (such as X or "Other") for people who do not identify as female or male. However, support varies substantially across countries, ranging from 67% in Malta to 7% in Bulgaria. Notably, the share of respondents who did not provide an answer also differs considerably between countries, suggesting varying levels of uncertainty or sensitivity regarding this issue.

Table 3 change the focus to ethcnic discrmination and ask people wheter they would be **confortable working dayly with a ROMA person**. For example, when it comes to how comfortable Europeans say

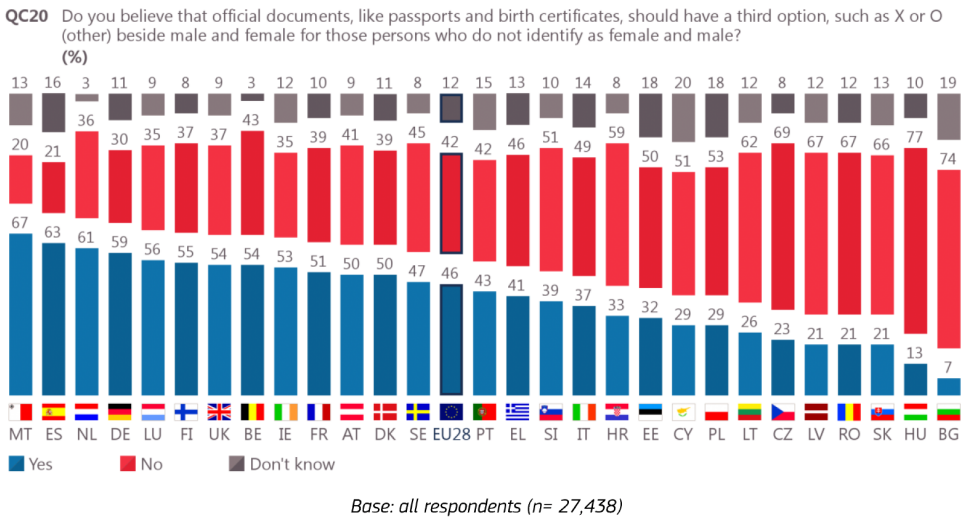

Figure 2: Table 2. Question QC20 by country

they would feel about having as a colleague at work a Roma person, the percentage of respondents saying that they would feel comfortable range between 38% in Italy or 40% in Bulgaria to 86% in the United Kingdom and Sweden and 89% in the Netherlands.

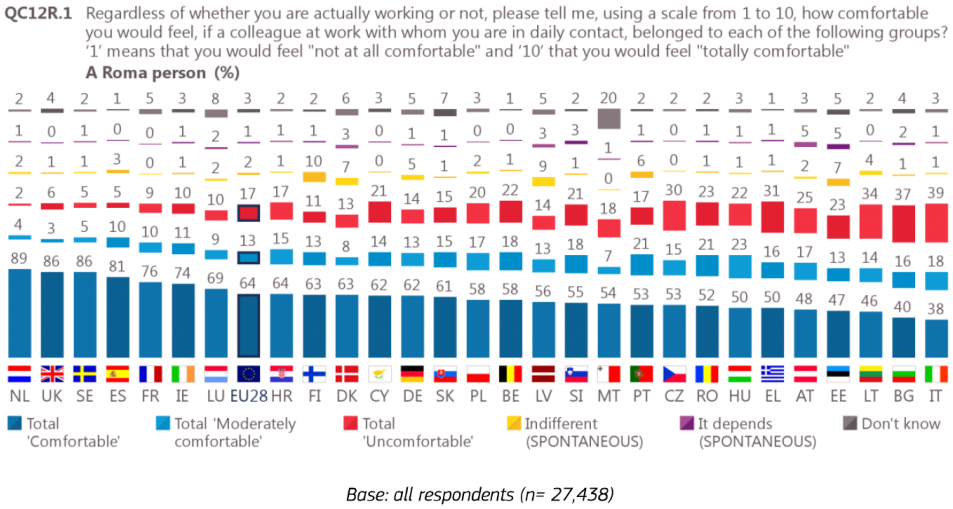

Figure 3: Table 3. Question QC12R.1 by country

CHALLENGE

You are working for the European Commission and have been tasked with **explaining cross-country variation in attitudes toward discrimination within the European Union**. Understanding how and why discrimination-related attitudes differ across countries is essential for the effective design, justification, and implementation of EU-level anti-discrimination policies, as policy interventions that are misaligned with prevailing public attitudes may face legitimacy, acceptance, or feasibility constraints.

To address this task, students must integrate **individual-level survey data** with **country-level indicators**. Individual-level variables may include socio-demographic characteristics, political orientations, and

To what extent do you agree or disagree with the following statement?: "Gay, lesbian and bisexual people should have the same rights as heterosexual
people"

value-based attitudes, while country-level variables may capture institutional arrangements, legal frameworks, cultural norms, economic conditions, and aggregate societal attitudes. Relevant country-level data can be sourced from Eurostat or other reputable cross-national databases.

Given the hierarchical structure of the data — individuals nested within countries — students should adopt a **multilevel analytical framework**. The analysis should rely on multilevel regression models that allow students to separate individual- and country-level variation, estimate contextual effects, and examine how national contexts shape individual attitudes beyond compositional differences. Where appropriate, cross-level interactions may also be explored. En example can be found here.

Successfully completing this assignment requires not only a solid understanding of the data and proficiency in quantitative analysis and statistical modelling, but also a nuanced interpretation of results, taking into account the social and political complexities surrounding discrimination-related attitudes in Europe.

The class will be divided into nine groups, each consisting of 3-4 students. The three research questions will be randomly assigned, with **each group working on one question**.

ABOUT THE DATA

The Special Eurobarometer 493: Discrimination in the EU focuses on person's perceptions, attitudes and opinions of discrimination based on ethnic origin, skin color, sexual orientation, gender, age, disability, religion, and beliefs. The survey you're referring to was conducted across 28 countries. Fieldwork: 09-21/05/2019

ASSIGMENT SUBMISSION GUIDELINES

Teams are required to submit a comprehensive project package, consisting of the following components:

- Replication files: well-documented source code used in the analysis, ensuring that all results presented in the data brief can be reproduced.
- Written report: a 4-5 pages summary (excluding references), formatted in 1.5 spacing, Calibri 11. The report must include:
  - short introduction to the case study
  - concise description of the data and analytical strategy
  - explanation of key methodological decisions
  - clear interpretation of the main empirical findings, using appropriate tables or figures
  - brief discussion of the results
  - Note: appendices may be included if necessary
- Oral presentation: 15-minute presentation of the main findings, followed by a 5-minute Q&A session. The discussion will be led by a randomly selected group and will also include questions from both students and the instructor.

EVALUATION CRITERIA

This assignment accounts for **50% of the final course grade** as follows:

- Written group assignment (30%)
- Oral presentation and discussion (20%)

Assessment will be guided by the following criteria:

- **Relevance:** originality and innovative thinking in framing the research question and addressing the task
- **Methodological adequacy:** appropriateness of the selected methods, including clear justification of the analytical strategy and modelling choices
- **Analytical rigor:** precision in the execution of the analysis and in the interpretation of empirical results

- **Quality of presentation:** clarity, structure, and professionalism in both the written report and the oral presentation

Prizes

- Best visualization: +0.5 points on the final grade (yes, you can get a 10.5 out of 10!)
- Best written/oral presentation: +0.5 points to the final grade (yes, you can achieve an 11 out of 10!)

PRESENTATION SCHEDULE

Final presentations are scheduled for March 18th. Each group will be allotted a 15-minute presentation, followed by a 5-minute Q&A session. Adherence to these time limits is mandatory.

Group	**Start Time**	**End Time**
Intro	3:00 PM	3:05 PM
Group 1	3:05 PM	3:25 PM
Group 2	3:30 PM	3:50 PM
Group 3	3:55 PM	4:15 PM
Break	4:15 PM	4:30 PM
Group 4	4:30 PM	4:50 PM
Group 5	4:55 PM	5:15 PM
Group 6	5:20 PM	5:40 PM
Break	5:40 PM	6:00 PM
Group 7	6:00 PM	6:20 PM
Group 8	6:25 PM	6:45 PM
Group 9	6:50 PM	7:10 PM

Table 1: Presentation Schedule

GOOD LUCK — AND ENJOY DIGGING INTO THE DATA!